The Small Business Guide to AI

How we fit AI into a business, and what it hands back to you: hours, money and fewer dropped balls.

A Next Sketch guide · About a 10-minute read



Building software isn't the hard part anymore

For years, software was slow and expensive to build. So software companies built one product for thousands of businesses, and every business bent itself to fit it.

You know how that goes. You pay every month for features you never use. Your data sits in someone else's system. And your team still copies the same info from one program into another.

That's changing. AI now builds software fast and cheap. **Building isn't the hard part anymore. Knowing what to build is.**

It also means you don't have to rent forever. If you want, what we build is yours to own: the tools, the platform and your data. The rest of this guide shows how we get there.

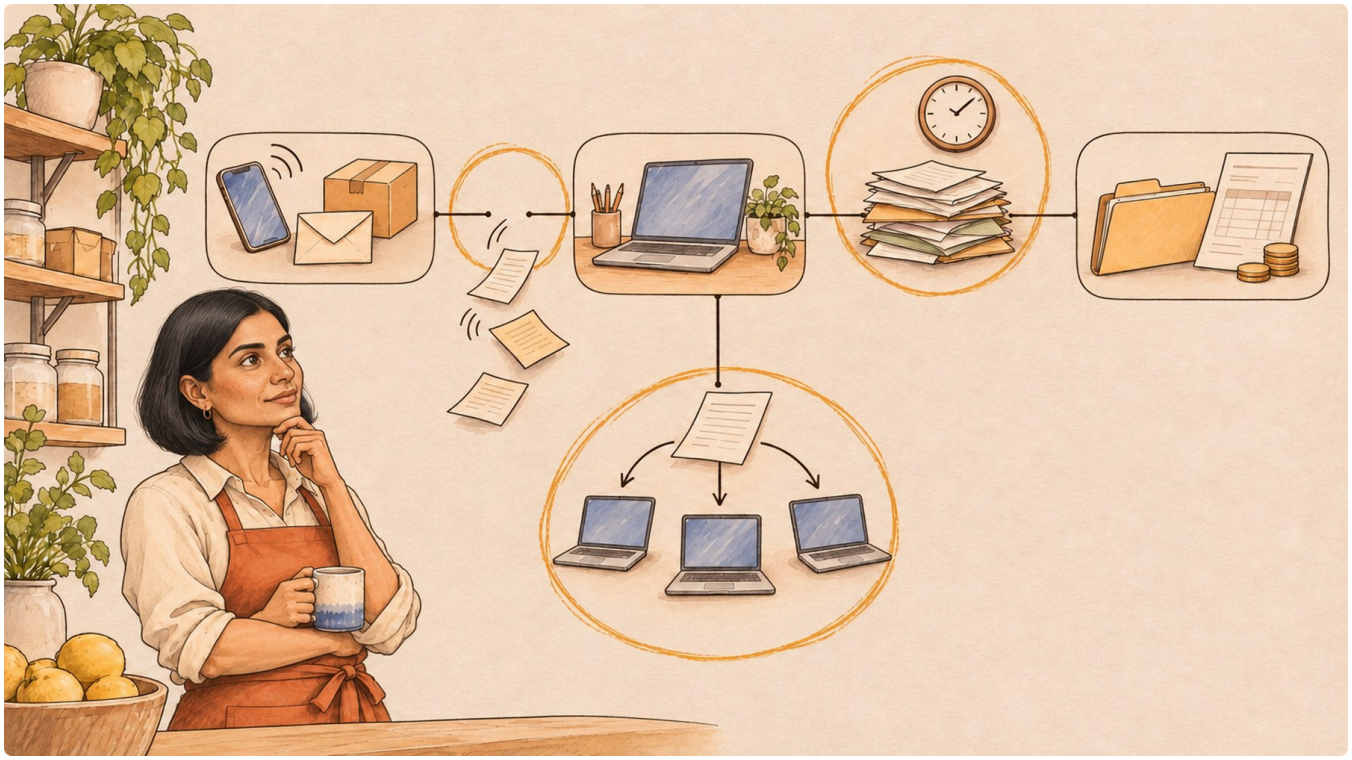
Where your time and money leak

Every business works the same basic way. Work comes in (a call, an email, an order), moves between people and programs, and goes out as a finished job and an invoice.

Most of the waste isn't inside the steps. It's **between** them:

- **Gaps:** the follow-up nobody remembered to send.
- **Handoffs:** the new lead that sat in someone's inbox all weekend.
- **Retyping:** the same customer info typed into three different programs.

One at a time, these leaks look small. Added up, they're not. **Quick math:** if someone on your team spends one hour a day retyping info, that's about 250 hours a year. At $25 an hour, that's over $6,000 spent on copy and paste.



How we fit AI into a business

We do it in four steps. The first two are about finding the money. The last two are about getting it back.

1. Map how work moves

We start by drawing how work actually moves through your business. Every map has four parts:

- **People:** who does the work.
- **Steps:** what happens, in what order.
- **Tools:** the programs the work runs through, like email, your calendar, invoicing and your customer list.
- **Paperwork:** the forms, quotes, invoices and records the work leaves behind.

Then we zoom in, the way a mechanic looks at a car, then the engine, then one part of the engine. We keep going until every piece of work has **one clear job and one owner.**



2. Find the leaks

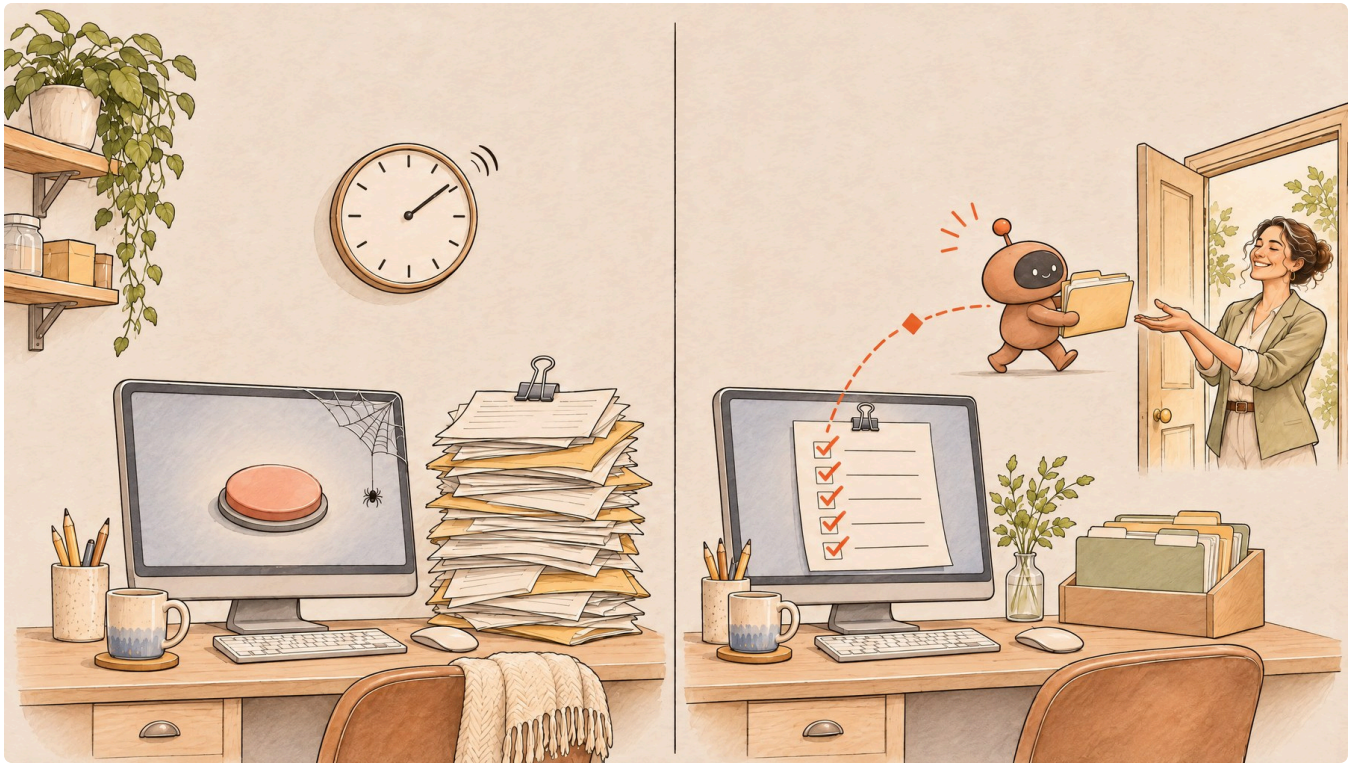
Once the map is detailed, the leaks show up on their own. They're almost always in the same places: slow handoffs, steps nobody owns, and info typed in twice.

We put a rough price on each one: hours lost a week, jobs missed, money waiting to be collected. Then we start with the leak that costs you the most.

3. Hand that job to an agent

The old fix for a leak was a new button, screen or report. But a button just sits there. Someone still has to remember to click it.

The new fix is an agent: AI that actually does the job, start to finish. **A button waits for someone to click it. An agent does the work.**

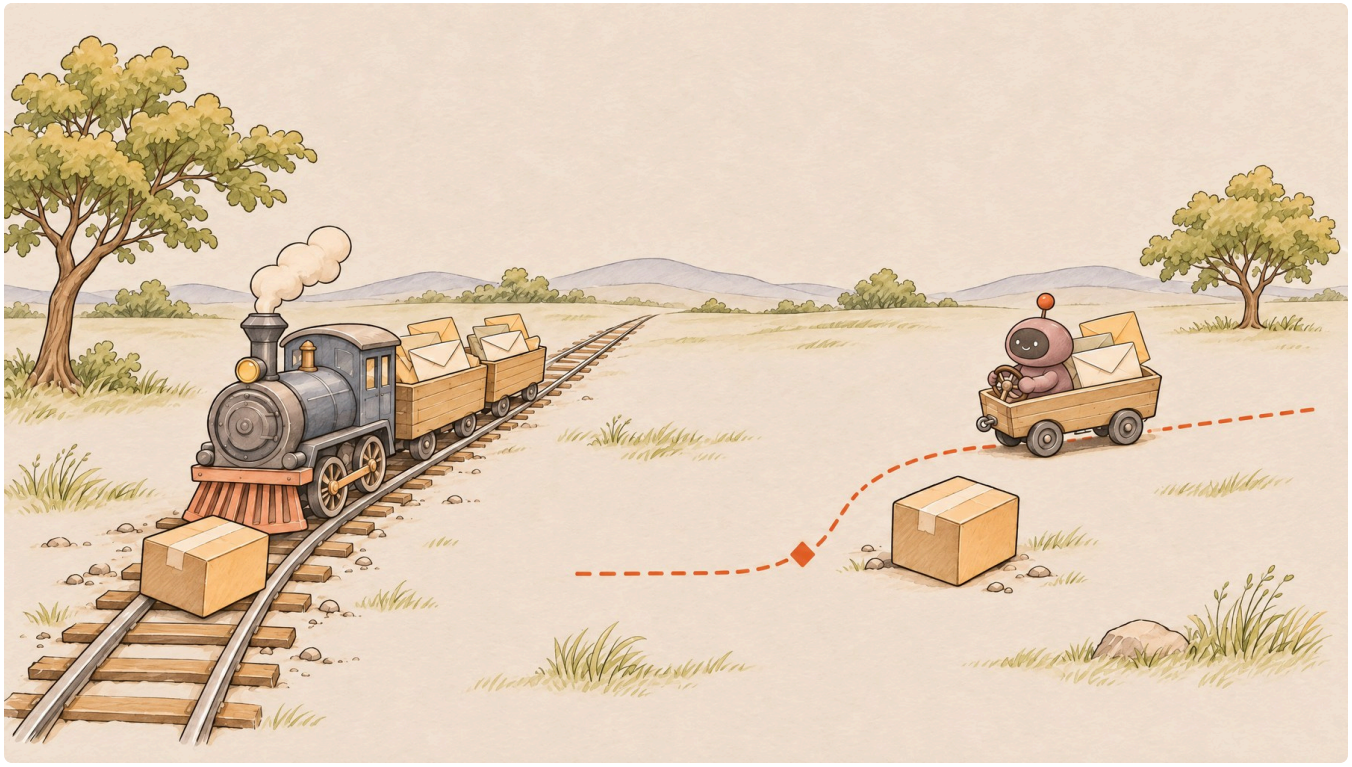


4. Keep it tuned

Your business doesn't stand still. You add a service, hire someone, change how you quote. We check in every month and adjust the agent so it keeps up.

Automations vs. agents: what's the difference?

You'll hear both words. Here's the simple version: **an automation is a train on a track. An agent can steer.**



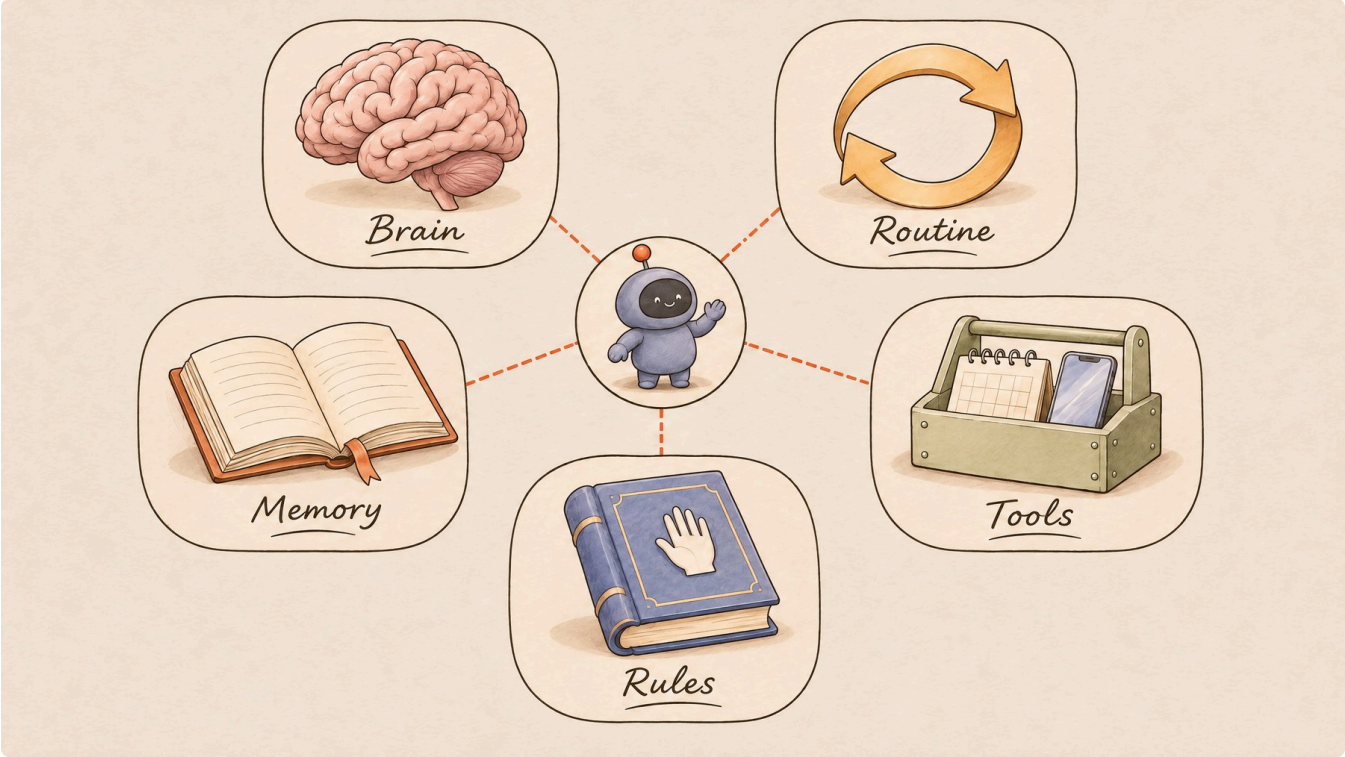
An automation does the same steps every time. "When a form comes in, add it to the spreadsheet and send the welcome email." It's great for simple jobs, until something unexpected lands on the track.

An agent handles jobs that need some judgment. It reads the message, figures out what the person wants, looks up their info, does the task and asks you when it's not sure.

	Automation	Agent
Best for	Simple jobs that are the same every time	Jobs that need a bit of judgment
When something unexpected happens	Stops, or does the wrong thing	Figures it out, or asks you
Example	Sends a receipt when an invoice is paid	Reads a customer's email, finds their order and drafts the reply

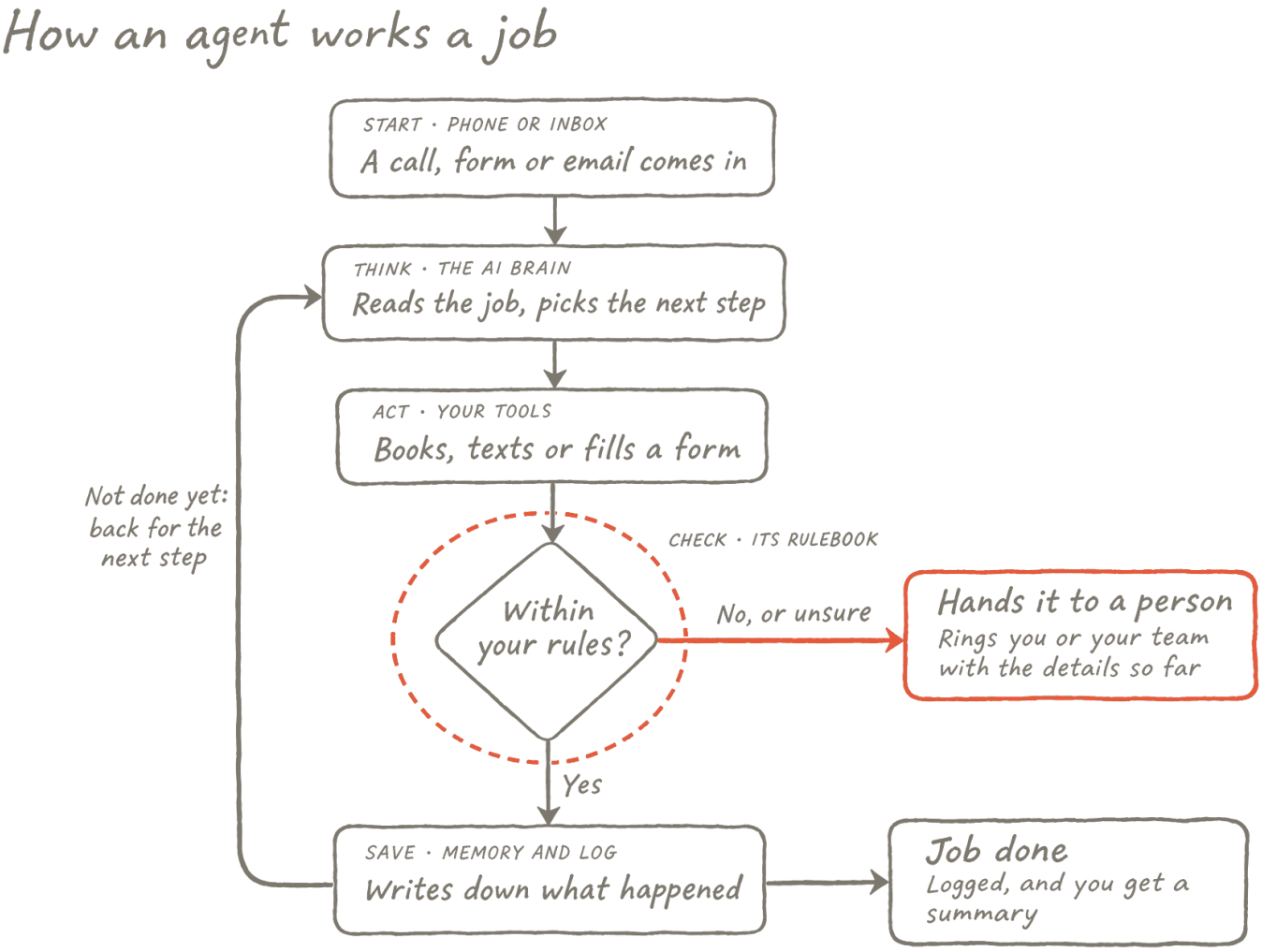
We use both. Automations handle the simple stuff, and agents take the jobs where judgment matters.

What's inside an agent



Think of an agent like a new hire who's great at one job. Every agent we build has the same five parts:

- **Brain:** the AI that thinks and decides what to do next.
- **Routine:** how it works a job. Something kicks it off, it does the work, checks its rules and notes what happened. It repeats until the job is done or handed to you.
- **Memory:** what it knows about your business, plus the history of every customer it's helped.
- **Tools:** the programs it uses, like your calendar, email or invoicing. It works with what you already have.
- **Rules:** your limits. What needs your OK, what it never does, and when to stop and ask a person.



Every job runs through this loop. If the agent is unsure, or a rule says stop, it hands the job to a person instead of guessing.

The five parts never change. What goes into them is all about you. Here's what we set up for the Intake agent, the one that answers new customers:

What we set up	Example: the Intake agent
What starts it	A new call, web form or text from someone who isn't a customer yet
What it needs to know	Your services, the area you serve, your hours and the questions people always ask
Its steps	Says it's an AI, asks your questions, confirms name and number, then books the job or passes it on
Tools it uses	Your phone line, calendar, customer list, email and text

What we set up	Example: the Intake agent
What it hands you	A filled-in intake form, a short call summary and a booked appointment
Its rules	No promises it can't keep, and urgent calls go straight to a person
How we know it's working	Calls answered, jobs booked, calls missed

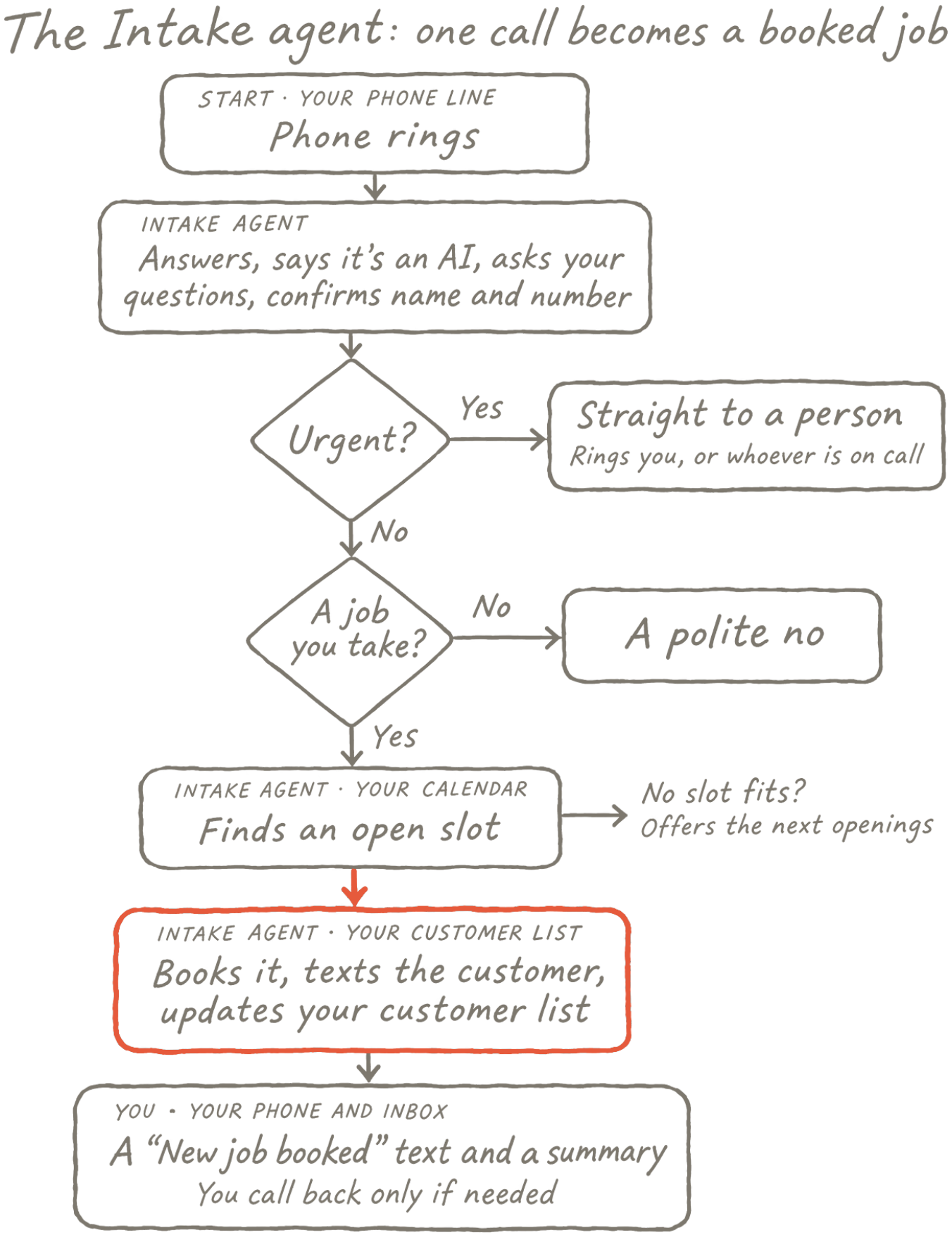
A Tuesday, before and after

Here's what the Intake agent looks like in a typical service business.



Before. You're up on a ladder when the phone rings. It goes to voicemail. You call back at 6 p.m., and they've already hired someone else. The calls that do get through end up on sticky notes, then get typed into your calendar, then into your customer list.

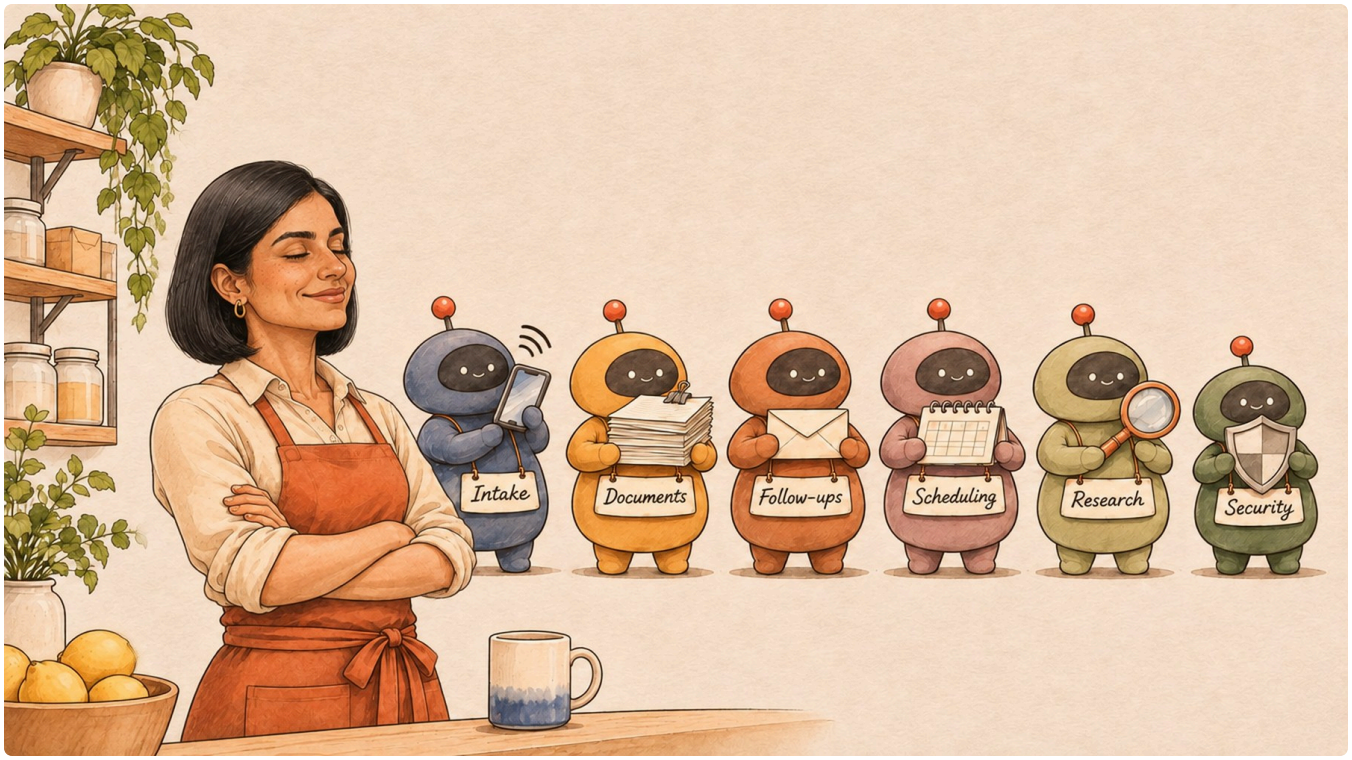
After. The agent answers on the first ring, day or night. It asks your questions, books an open slot and texts the customer a confirmation. You get a quick text: "New job booked, Thursday at 10." The details are already in your calendar and customer list.


The Intake agent: one call becomes a booked job
START · YOUR PHONE LINE
Phone rings
INTAKE AGENT
Answers, says it's an AI, asks your questions, confirms name and number
Urgent?
Yes
Straight to a person
Rings you, or whoever is on call
No
A job you take?
No
A polite no
Yes
INTAKE AGENT · YOUR CALENDAR
Finds an open slot
No slot fits?
Offers the next openings
INTAKE AGENT · YOUR CUSTOMER LIST
Books it, texts the customer, updates your customer list
YOU · YOUR PHONE AND INBOX
A "New job booked" text and a summary
You call back only if needed

Every step runs in the tools you already use. You only step in when the agent hands something to a person.

What that's worth. Say you miss five calls a week, and just one of them would have become a $400 job. That's about $400 a week, or more than $20,000 a year, you stop losing to voicemail. Plus the evenings you're not spending on callbacks and data entry.

Five agents most businesses start with



Software that fits you, not the other way around

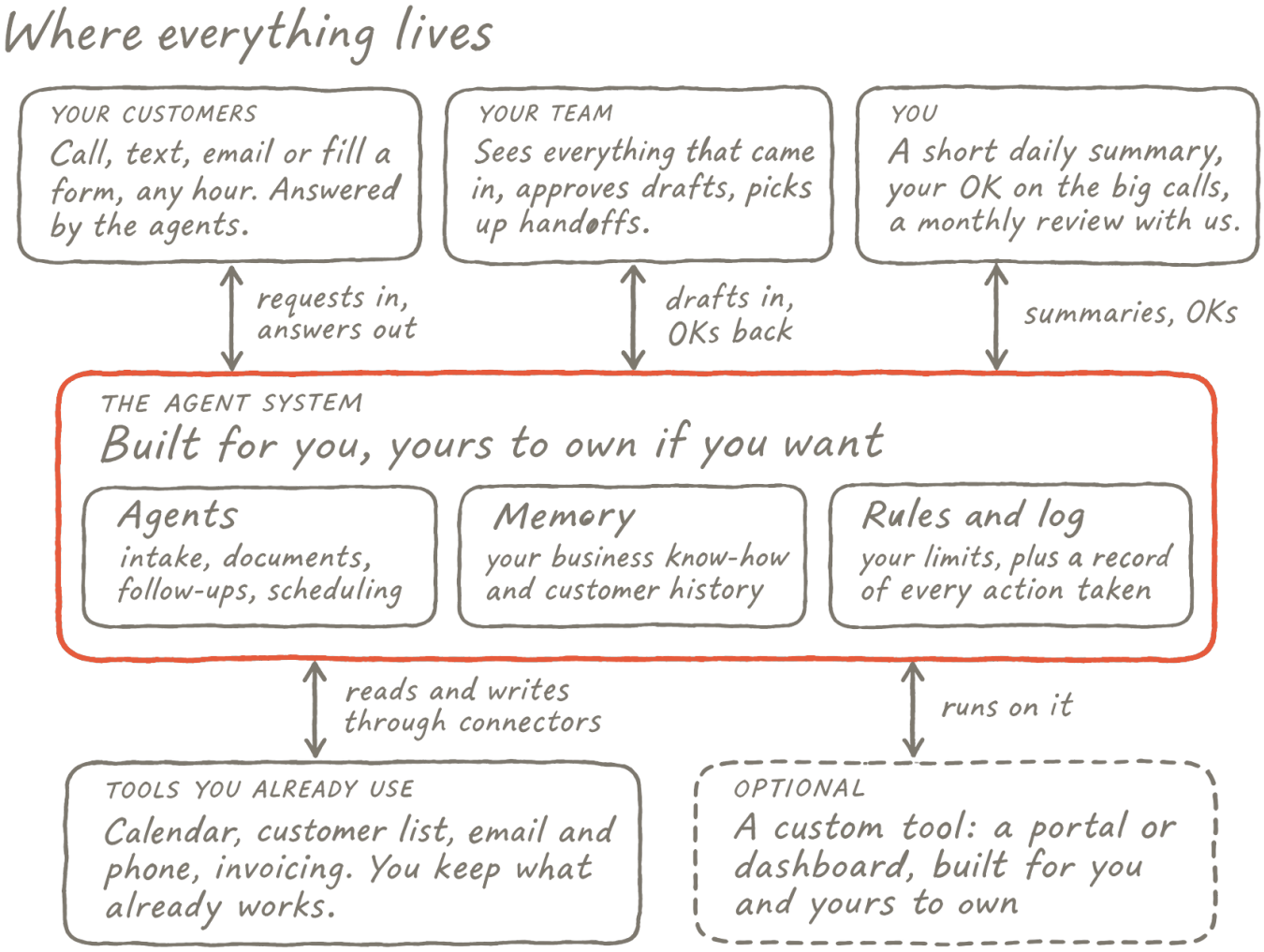
Old software asked you to change how you work. We build around how you already work.

Sometimes that means agents working inside the platforms you have now (your CRM, email, project management platform etc..). Sometimes it means a tool (Software) built just for you: a customer portal, a dashboard your team runs the day from, or one system that ties your calls, paperwork and follow-ups together.

Either way, it's built around you:

- **Your steps, in your order.** The agent follows the process your team already trusts.
- **Your tools stay.** We connect to what you already pay for and only build what's missing.
- **Your rules.** You decide what needs your OK and what never leaves the business.

- **Your words.** Agents use your templates, your wording and your answers to the questions customers always ask.
- **Yours to own, if you want it.** The tools, the platform and your data can live in accounts you own, not ours.



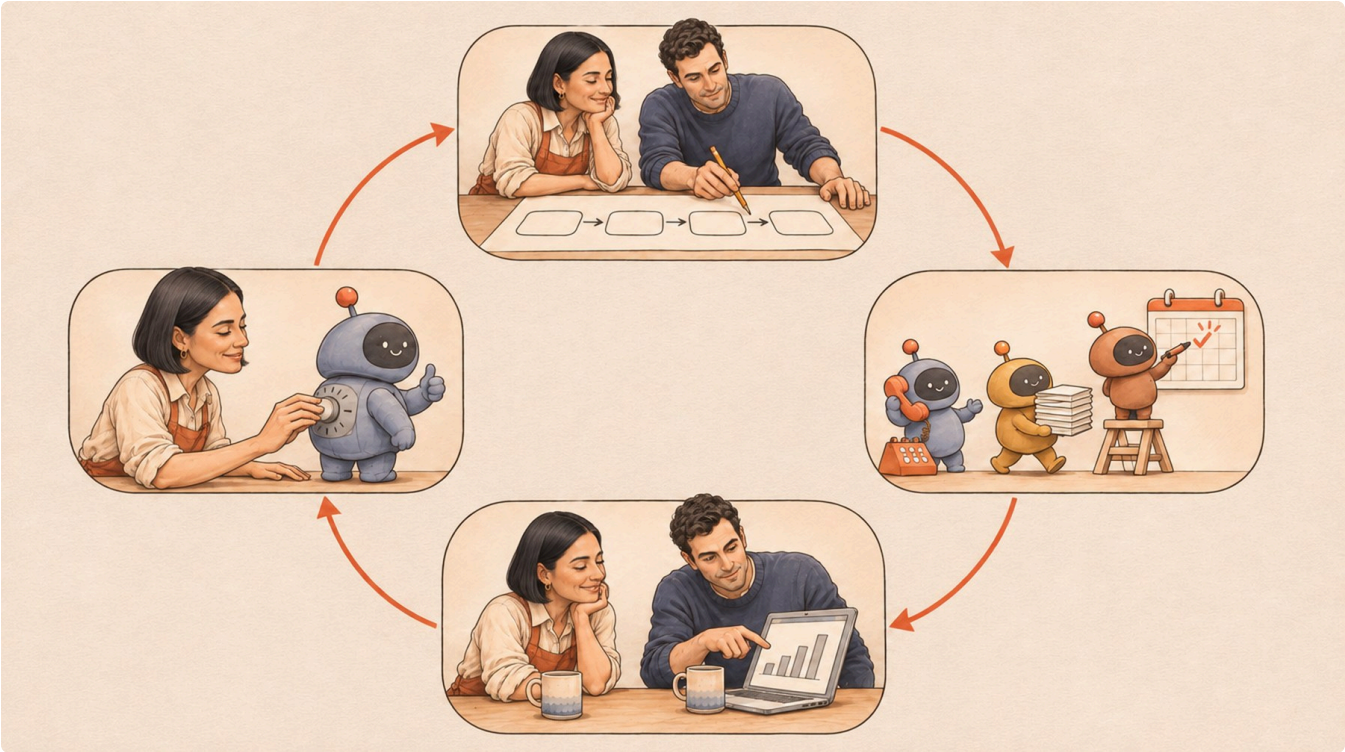
The agents work inside the tools you already pay for. A custom tool only gets built when your business needs one.

It gets better, not older

Most software is at its best the day you buy it. Then your business changes and the software doesn't, or it changes in ways nobody asked for. Ours works the other way around:

1. **Everything gets logged.** Each agent keeps a record of what it did and when it handed off to a person.

2. **We review it with you every month.** What the agents handled, where they got stuck, what customers keep asking for.
3. **We tune what's there.** Change a step, tighten a rule, teach it something new.
4. **We add what's next.** When the review turns up a new leak, it gets its own agent.



New service, new hire, new way of quoting? We update the map, and the agents keep up.

You stay in charge

Agents do the busywork. You make the calls. Every agent has clear limits and hands off to a person when something is urgent, unclear or outside its rules.

Try this: map one job this week

Pick one job that eats your week, like answering new customer calls, writing quotes or chasing invoices. Then answer these:

- [ ] What starts it? A call, an email, a form, a walk-in?
- [ ] Who touches it, and in what order?
- [ ] Which programs does it pass through?
- [ ] What paperwork does it leave behind?

- [ ] Where does it wait, get dropped or get typed in twice?
- [ ] How many hours a week does it take?

Now multiply those hours by what that person's time costs you. That's what this one job costs you every week. It's probably your first agent.

Want help with the rest?



We'll map your business with you, find the biggest leaks and show you what an agent would hand back in hours and dollars. **Start a conversation at hello@nextsketch.com.**